12

Language Endangerment and Revitalization

As part of an article on endangered languages that appeared in *The New Yorker* magazine in 2005, journalist Elizabeth Kolbert made an appointment to interview Chief Marie Smith Jones, the last remaining full-blooded member of the Eyak nation and the last remaining native speaker of the Eyak language. When Kolbert arrived at Chief Smith Jones's apartment in Anchorage, Alaska, however, no one answered the door. It turned out that Chief Smith Jones had decided she did not want to be interviewed after all. When the Chief heard that Kolbert, upon the advice of a friend of the Chief's, had brought some halibut, however, she changed her mind and allowed an interview that ended up lasting several hours. Chief Smith Jones, whom Kolbert described as an 87-year-old woman with wispy white hair, a face covered in fine wrinkles, and wrists no wider than a child's, had strong emotions about the imminent loss of her language, which would inevitably accompany her own death. When Kolbert asked her how she felt about the loss of her native language, Chief Smith Jones answered, "How would you feel if your baby died? If someone asked you, 'What was it like to see it lying in the cradle?' So think about that before you ask that kind of question" (Kolbert 2005:46; cf. Nevins 2013; Rice 2014; Thurman 2015).

Chief Marie Smith Jones died on January 21, 2008, at the age of 89, and the Eyak language died with her.

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Many other last speakers of endangered languages all over the world have passed away in recent decades. Here are just a few of the final speakers of some of these languages (Nettle and Romaine 2000:1–2).

Arthur Bennett, the last person who knew more than a few words of Mbabaram, an Aboriginal language, died in 1972 in north Queensland, Australia. Linguist R.M.W. Dixon describes his search for the remaining speakers of Mbabaram in his memoir, and reports that Arthur Bennett was at first unconvinced when Dixon told him Mbabaram was so important he would make sure it was put in a museum. "You know what we call 'dog'?" Dixon reports that Bennett asked him. Dixon continues: "I waited anxiously. 'We call it *dog*.' My heart sank …" (Dixon 1984:107). Eventually, however, Bennett agreed to help Dixon with his research on Mbabaram.

Ned Maddrell, the last native speaker of Manx, a Gaelic language spoken on the Isle of Man, located in the Irish Sea between Great Britain and Ireland, died in 1974. Though Manx no longer has any native speakers, it is being learned as a second language in many schools on the Isle of Man, and is the medium of instruction in at least one primary school on the island (Hinton and Hale 2001:103, 299).

Pat Gabori, whose traditional name is Kabararrjingathi bulthuku, was in 2010, one of only eight remaining speakers of Kayardild, an Aboriginal language spoken on Bentinck Island, Australia. Nicholas Evans reports (2010:xv–xvi) that Pat Gabori, who was elderly and blind when Evans last saw him, loved to talk for hours about hunting, intricate tribal genealogies, and sacred spaces on Bentinck Island. His comprehensive knowledge of tribal law allowed him to make a valuable contribution as a witness in a recent Aboriginal court case to obtain recognition of traditional sea rights.

Laura Fish Somersal, the last speaker of Wappo, a Native American language formerly spoken in the area north of San Francisco, died in 1990. The only reason Somersal retained her Wappo fluency, according to researchers who recently published a Wappo grammar (Thompson et al. 2006) based on information provided by Somersal, was that Somersal was excused as a child from attending the Bureau of Indian Affairs school in her area because she had to stay home to take care of her blind mother. Had she attended school, she would

have become literate – but she also would have been forced to speak only English and would probably have lost her fluency in Wappo. This was fortunate for the researchers' study of Wappo, they report, "but not good for Laura."[1]

Tevfic Esenç, who lived on a farm in Turkey, had already decided years before he died in 1992, what he wanted inscribed on his gravestone: "This is the grave of Tevfic Esenç. He was the last person able to speak the language they call Ubykh."

Putting a human face on the abstract crisis known as language endangerment, language extinction, or language death helps to shed light on some of the actual experiences and feelings of the last speakers of the many languages of the world thought to be close to disappearing. What is it like to speak a language with ten or fewer speakers? Linguist K. David Harrison, who has traveled around the world documenting endangered languages, says that for people like Vasya Gabov of Siberia, who is one of the last speakers of the Ös language, it means feeling isolated and having very few opportunities to speak one's language. It also means feeling nearly invisible, surrounded by speakers of a much larger, much more dominant language who do not even acknowledge the existence of other languages. It can also mean forgetting words and grammatical rules because of a lack of opportunities to speak one's native language in actual social contexts. "In this situation, one shared by speakers of thousands of small languages worldwide, it becomes hard to be heard, hard not to forget, hard not to become invisible" (Harrison 2007:4–5).

In this chapter, we take a close look at the phenomenon of language endangerment, as well as at some language revitalization efforts. First, we review various estimates of the extent of the crisis and also explore some of the advantages and disadvantages for different audiences of attempting to quantify the number of languages in danger of disappearing. We also discuss the various reasons for the extinction of so many languages. Then, we ask what dies when a language dies – what, in other words, does it mean for a language to become "extinct"? Is it comparable to the extinction of a biological species? What are the implications of using these kinds of metaphors to describe language endangerment? Finally, we will look at some case studies of language revitalization programs, exploring some of the logistical and ethical dilemmas involved in documenting and revitalizing endangered languages.

Enumerating the Crisis: How Many Endangered Languages are There?

In a much-cited overview of the status of endangered language around the world, linguist Michael Krauss admits that "statistics on language viability are very hard to come by" (Krauss 1992:4). For one thing, many of the places around the world with the highest concentration of languages are in remote places that have not been thoroughly, or even partially, surveyed by scholars. In addition, many governments are either unaware of, or actively hostile to, speakers of languages aside from the ones recognized by the state, so government figures often cannot be relied upon. Moreover, many languages have already disappeared over the past millennia; there is no way of knowing anything about these, since most had no script associated with them and therefore disappeared without a trace. And of course, as we have noted several times in this book already, there is a fundamental dilemma regarding the enumeration of languages (endangered or otherwise): there is no agreed-upon set of criteria that would distinguish a language from a dialect, other than the one with which linguist Max Weinreich is credited – that a language has an army and a navy, whereas a dialect does not. In addition, there are many hybrid linguistic variants that call into question the very existence of any bounded entity that could be termed either a language or a dialect. The "socially charged life" of language, as Bakhtin called it, is far messier than the shelves of published grammars of individual languages would lead one to believe.

The great poet and scholar A.K. Ramanujan acknowledged that "the chief difficulty of translation is its impossibility" (1989:47) – and then proceeded to discuss how best to translate a poem. Similarly, many linguists have acknowledged the difficulties (and even the impossibility) of ever coming up with an accurate number of languages in the world – and then have gone ahead and produced estimates. One of the most frequently consulted sources for this information is *Ethnologue: Languages of the World* (Simons and Fennig 2020), a database of the world's languages compiled by the Summer Institute of Linguistics, a Christian group dedicated to documenting as many languages as possible, partly in order to translate the Bible into each language.

Ethnologue estimates that there were 7,117 languages in the world as of 2020. The distribution of speakers among these languages is quite striking: less than three tenths of one percent (200) of the world's languages are spoken as native languages by more than 88 percent of the world's populations, and hundreds of millions more people speak one of these languages as second languages.[2] While it is difficult to estimate how many first (or native) speakers there are of any given language, it is even more difficult to estimate how many second (or subsequent) speakers there are of that language. Nevertheless, Ethnologue's estimates indicate that English, Mandarin Chinese, Hindi, and Spanish are the most commonly spoken, either as first or subsequently learned languages (see Figures 12.1 and 12.2).

Languages are not spread evenly across the globe. Instead, there are "hotspots of language diversity" (Harrison 2007:10–13) and relative linguistic deserts. For example, in all of Saudi Arabia, according to *Ethnologue*, there are estimated to be only seven languages spoken. In contrast, in Papua New Guinea, a country a quarter of the size of Saudi Arabia, an estimated 840 languages are spoken. Similarly, the 65 inhabited islands of Vanuatu in the South Pacific, together roughly the size of Connecticut, support 110 different languages (Simons and Fennig 2020; cf. Grenoble and Whaley 1998:vii).

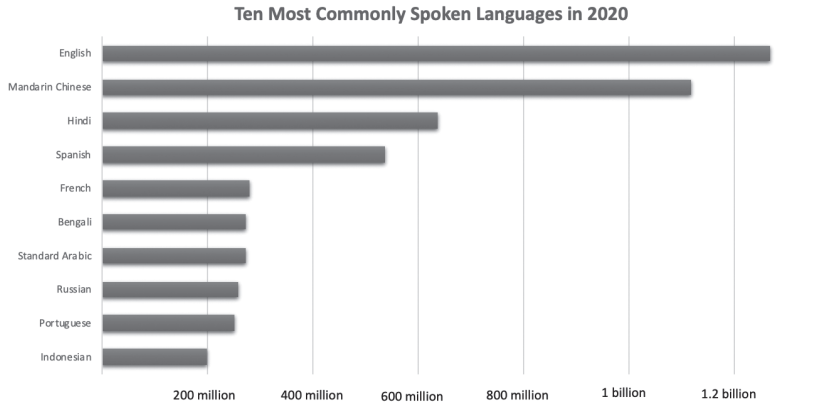


Figure 12.1 Ten most commonly spoken languages in the world in 2020 (including those spoken as second languages).
Source: Adapted from Simons and Fennig (2020), Ethnologue, 23rd edition, https://www.ethnologue.com/guides/ethnologue200.

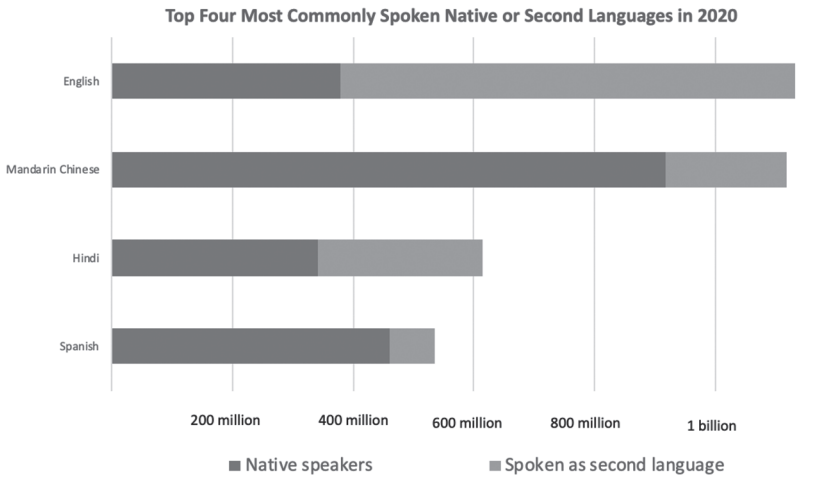


Figure 12.2 Top four most commonly spoken native or second languages in the world in 2020 (including those spoken as second languages).
Source: Adapted from Simons and Fennig (2020), Ethnologue, 23rd edition, https://www.ethnologue.com/guides/ethnologue200.

Even more challenging, perhaps, than coming up with the total number of languages currently spoken around the world is the task of assessing which ones are likely to survive and which ones are endangered. Scholars have come up with various criteria and classifications, such as the following commonly used ones proposed by Michael Krauss (1992:4–7):

- *Safe languages*. Those languages that have official government support and/or large numbers of speakers. If the threshold is placed at 100,000 speakers in order for the language to be considered "safe," Krauss states that only 10 percent of all the world's are "safe."
- *Endangered languages*. Those languages that, though they are still being learned by children, will cease to be learned by children in the next century if present conditions persist.
- *Moribund languages*. Those languages that have ceased to be learned by children, and are therefore almost certainly doomed to extinction.
- *Dead or extinct languages*. Those languages that are no longer spoken by anyone, even if there are written materials or recordings in those languages.

Michael Krauss (1992:5), drawing on his own work with many endangered languages, provides the following often-cited numbers for the situation as it was in 1992:

- In Alaska, only two of the 20 Native languages (Central Yupik and Siberian Yupik of St Lawrence Island), or only 10 percent, are still being learned by children.
- Among the languages of the northern minorities of Siberia, only three of the 30, again only 10 percent, are still being learned by children.
- For all of the United States and Canada together, 149 of the 187, or 80 percent, of the Native languages are moribund.
- In Central and South American, the situation is less dire, with about 50 of 300 of the indigenous Meso-American and 110 of 400 of the indigenous South American languages considered moribund.
- In Australia, 90 percent of the estimated 250 Aboriginal languages are moribund, with most of the remaining ones very close to extinction.

Overall, though it is virtually impossible to know for sure, Krauss states that since only 10 percent of the world's languages can be considered "safe," many of the rest are in danger of becoming extinct. He therefore estimates that as many as half of the world's languages may disappear in the next hundred years (1992:6). Many languages have already ceased to be spoken in the decades since Krauss made that prediction. A more recent estimate by *Ethnologue* states that 2,926 of the world's 7,117 languages (41 percent) are endangered (Simons and Fennig 2020).

This figure is alarming, and many linguists, public officials, and ordinary citizens have committed themselves to attempting to stem the tide of language death. Organizations such as the Endangered Language Fund, the National Science Foundation, the National Endowment for the Humanities, and the Summer Institute of Linguistics have supported research and documentation efforts, as well as revitalization efforts on the part of communities and individuals. Some of these programs will be described later in this chapter. First, though, it is important to take a step back and look critically for a moment at the tendency toward enumeration, even though such

numerical estimates are, as we have already noted, at best partial and at worst utterly misleading.

What are the problematic assumptions underlying the desire to count the number of endangered languages, and the number of speakers each endangered language has? Jane Hill (2002:127–128; cf. Duchêne and Heller 2007, Davis 2017) names several. First, though she acknowledges that numbers can be powerful "calls to action" that have been used to mobilize activists to reverse the trend toward language death, and though Hill herself has been involved in such efforts, she warns that journalists and the mass media are soundbite oriented and cannot or will not devote enough time or space to explaining the difficulties or subtleties involved in quantifying languages or speakers. Second, Hill warns that numbers and statistics that are meant for one kind of audience – speakers of dominant languages, perhaps, who have the power to do something about the extinction of smaller languages – can have very negative effects when heard by a very different kind of audience – the speakers of endangered languages themselves. Hill reminds her readers that numbers have often been used by colonial powers in the past as one means of control, what Foucault would call governmentality through enumeration. Speakers of endangered languages are often fearful, she warns, that numbers can be (and have been) held against them, and they can therefore become fearful or resentful.

Some speakers of endangered languages can also feel that scholars' estimates of the number of speakers of their languages – of "native" speakers, or "partial" speakers, or "bilingual" speakers – are disrespectful to them. Sometimes, younger speakers attempt to reclaim their ancestral languages, "often through heroic work with linguistic archives," but are not considered "real" speakers of the language by researchers (Hill 2002:128). Thus, enumeration can end up alienating the very individuals in a community who are the most highly motivated to preserve a language.

Most troubling, Hill maintains, are the language ideologies that underpin the drive toward enumeration in language endangerment studies. Among these language ideologies are ones we have discussed earlier in the book, such as the assumption of monolingualism – what Michael Silverstein (1996) has called the "culture of monoglot standardization" – which can be complicated in areas where languages are endangered because the norm in such places is often complex

multilingualism. Speakers of endangered languages can also be put off, Hill warns, by assumption of the "pricelessness" of their languages and assertions by language activists and scholars that such languages "belong" to all of humanity. We will have more to say about these language ideologies and others later in the chapter.

What Dies When a Language Dies?

How significant is it that the native languages from which English borrowed words such as moose, raccoon, and the name of the state Massachusetts are all dead? What dies when a language dies? Many scholars working in the field of language endangerment have mourned the passing of even a single language by remarking upon the richness that is present in any one of the world's thousands of languages. Marianne Mithun, for example, a linguist who specializes in North American indigenous languages, most of which are moribund or already extinct, writes:

> There is not a language in North America that fails to offer breathtakingly beautiful intricacy. For descendants of speakers to discover this beauty can profoundly enrich their lives, much like the discovery of music, literature, or art, if not more … Language represents the most creative, pervasive aspect of culture, the most intimate side of the mind. The loss of language diversity will mean that we will never even have the opportunity to appreciate the full creative capacities of the human mind. (1998:189)

K. David Harrison, another linguist who works on endangered languages all over the world, lists three areas of loss if we fail to safeguard and document languages at risk of extinction: (1) the erosion of the human knowledge base, especially local ecological knowledge; (2) the loss of cultural heritage; and (3) failure to acquire a full understanding of human cognitive capacities (2007:15–19). With regard to the first area of loss, Harrison notes that an estimated 87 percent of the world's plants and animals have not yet been identified or studied by modern scientists. If we are to hope that a cure to cancer, the coronavirus, or other horrible diseases might be found in the Amazon, or in Papua New Guinea, or if we want to learn about more sustainable

forms of agriculture from people who have been living in harmony in their environments for many hundreds of years, then we should recognize, Harrison writes, that "most of what humankind knows about the natural world lies completely outside of science textbooks, libraries, and databases, existing only in unwritten languages in people's memories" – that is, mostly in unwritten endangered languages (2007:15). Of course, some of this knowledge can be communicated in a different language, assuming the person speaking the endangered language is bilingual, but oftentimes there is a "massive disruption of the transfer of traditional knowledge across generations" when a group switches from an endangered language to a dominant language (2007:16). Particular languages are often especially rich in those areas of the lexicon, such as reindeer herding, botany, or fishing, that are most important to the speakers of those languages, and a great deal of ecologically specific knowledge is encoded in those languages for particular cultural practices. It is not surprising, then, that much of that knowledge is not passed on when the language (and often the way of life as well) dies.

The second area of loss that Harrison describes is the loss of cultural heritage that can accompany the loss of a language. Myths, jokes, wordplay, wise sayings, and other forms of verbal art are just some of the cultural practices that can be lost when a language becomes extinct. "Language is the most massive and inclusive art we know, a mountainous and anonymous work of unconscious generations," the famous linguistic anthropologist Edward Sapir declared (1949[1933], cited in Crystal 2000:40). Even when myths or sayings are translated into another language, there is always something lost. Trying to preserve the whole corpus of an endangered language's verbal art is virtually impossible, even with modern technology such as videotaping, for once a language disappears, the linguistic practices specific to the speakers of that language also disappear.

The third area of loss Harrison identifies is the ability to acquire a full understanding of the capabilities of the human mind. Linguists and cognitive scientists make assumptions about what the human brain can and cannot do based on experiments and existing data. One source of such data is the group of languages that have been studied by linguists. Whenever a language is analyzed for the first time, scholars look to see what patterns it shares grammatically with other languages in the world and which features it has that might

be unique. The more languages that die, the more likely it is that the conclusions scholars draw about the limits of human cognition might be mistaken. For example, the language of Urarina, which is spoken by only 3,000 people in the Amazon rainforest of Peru, has a very unusual word order for its sentences. Unlike English, which generally uses the Subject – Verb – Object (S-V-O) word order, as in sentences such as, "The girl rode the bike," Urarina uses the Object – Verb – Subject (O-V-S) word order, which would have a literal translation for this sentence as, "The bike rode the girl." O-V-S word order is extremely rare among the world's languages. "Were it not for Urarina and a few other Amazonian languages," Harrison writes, "scientists might not even suspect it were possible. They would be free to hypothesize – falsely – that O-V-S word order was cognitively impossible, that the human brain could not process it" (2007:19).

Similarly, Kayardild, the Australian Aboriginal language spoken by Pat Gabori, who was described at the outset of this chapter, does not have one of the grammatical features – a restriction on the use of noun affixes to express tense – that Steven Pinker and other Chomskyan linguists have said were universal across all languages. "Kayardild shows us how dangerous it is to talk about 'universals' of language on the basis of a narrow sample that ignores the true extent of the world's linguistic diversity" (Evans 2010:xvi).

David Crystal, a prolific linguist who has written on many topics, including language death, presents five answers to the question, "Why should we care if a language dies?" (Crystal 2000:32–67). His answers provide a slightly different angle on language loss but make many of the same arguments that Harrison does. Here are Crystal's five reasons for why we should care if a language dies:

1 Because we need diversity.
2 Because language expresses identity.
3 Because languages are repositories of history.
4 Because languages contribute to the sum of human knowledge.
5 Because languages are interesting in themselves.

Throughout these arguments, Crystal, like many other scholars, explicitly likens the extinction of a language to the extinction of a biological species. In nature, genetic diversity ensures that at least some species will be able to adapt to changes in the environment.

For similar reasons, Crystal argues, cultural and linguistic diversity is important. Some scholars go even further than Crystal, stating that biological and linguistic diversity are intrinsically linked. Nettle and Romaine, for example, talk of "biolinguistic diversity – the rich spectrum of life encompassing all the earth's species of plants and animals along with human cultures and their languages" (2000:13). Should we be less concerned, they ask, about the passing of Taiap (the language studied by Don Kulick, discussed in earlier chapters) than the passing of the California condor? In fact, they conclude, these two kinds of extinction are not just metaphorically connected but actually connected, for in order to preserve biodiversity, the people whose environments are at risk must be enlisted to help. Since they are the ones with the most knowledge about that environment, they must be empowered, Nettle and Romaine argue, to control these natural resources themselves. It is peripheral rural communities, they claim, "who are in the environments where the biodiversity is, who are poor and marginalized by unsustainable development, and who are the stewards of most linguistic and cultural diversity. To a very significant extent, common cause can be made among development, biodiversity, and linguistic diversity" (Nettle and Romaine 2000:165).

But some scholars have recently critiqued the use of biological analogies in the rhetoric surrounding language endangerment. Shaylih Muehlmann (2007:15), for instance, claims that these discourses essentialize language, nature, and indigenous people in ways that mask the complexities of situations that often involve multilingualism and marginalization. Indigenous people are on the one hand valorized and held up as "stewards," Muehlmann argues, and on the other hand exoticized and treated in a simplistic, often disrespectful manner, with assumptions being made about their preferences, life goals, and interests. People are made into "icons rather than agents" (Muehlmann 2007:22; cf. Hoffman 2008:50). It can sometimes be the case, in other words, that indigenous people who speak endangered languages are used as symbols in an endeavor that, while well-intentioned, might actually be more in the interests of the powerful, such as scholars, development workers, or government officials, than in the interests of the speakers themselves.

Deborah Cameron (2007a) has also cautioned against the assumptions and language ideologies underlying endangered languages rhetoric. While she does not deny the seriousness of potential language

loss, she finds it very troubling that languages are unproblematically equated with endangered animal species. She also takes exception to statements such as this one, which was made by the Chairman of the US National Endowment for the Humanities, Bruce Cole, in a press release announcing the decision by the NEH and the National Science Foundation to fund language documentation projects jointly: "Language is the DNA of a culture, and it is the vehicle for the traditions, customs, stories, history, and beliefs of a people. A lost language is a lost culture" (Cole, cited in Cameron 2007a:274). This sort of rhetoric, Cameron maintains, borrows the authority of modern genetics to make an argument whose origins lie back in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. The one nation/one language/one people ideology espoused by German philosophers such as Johann Gottfried von Herder and William von Humboldt underpins many of the discourses surrounding language endangerment, Cameron asserts, even among scholars and activists with good intentions who otherwise hold very different views of language. This language ideology assumes no internal dissent within a group of people, no multilingualism, and no change over time that does not come from the outside. This "monoglot ideology" (Silverstein 1996) is a homogenous, static view of language and culture that has long since been discarded in linguistic and cultural anthropology. Moreover, Cameron warns, it is not that different from the language ideology espoused by the Nazis in Germany, who also held an essentialistic view of peoples, languages, and nations. The Nazis even tried to preserve certain German dialects and Celtic languages, Cameron notes. Of course, she does not equate those working in endangered language preservation today with Nazis; she is simply pointing out that the connection between "speaking A" and "being A" is much more complicated and fluid than some of the rhetoric would suggest (Cameron 2007a:280; cf. Woolard 2016:62). The multifunctionality of all linguistic practices guarantees that the way in which one speaks can index multiple identities simultaneously, and any given identity can have many different kinds of links (or no link at all) to a particular language.

Alexandra Jaffe (2007) discovered the problems with too simplistic an approach to language and identity in her research on Corsican. Revitalization efforts that emphasized a purist, homogeneous view ended up stigmatizing many habitual language practices, such as code-switching between French and Corsican. Also, not all Corsicans

can speak Corsican, so this language ideology ended up causing feelings of linguistic insecurity and cultural inauthenticity among Corsicans who were not fluent speakers of the language. Eventually, Jaffe notes, a "polynomic" language ideology came to dominate Corsican preservation efforts. This ideology is pluralist and anti-purist in nature, allowing for many different varieties of Corsican to exist and not stigmatizing anyone for their level of proficiency or their code-switching (2007:65).

Perhaps the clearest indication of the problematic nature of the some of the language ideologies underpinning the discourses on language endangerment is the use of the very same language ideologies to support claims of language endangerment for languages that are clearly not endangered, such as English (Schmidt 2007; Duchêne and Heller 2007). The "English Only" movement, some scholars argue, has borrowed the rhetoric of language endangerment to suggest that English must be made the official language of the United States, or else it will be overrun by other languages (Baron 1990). Like all other languages, English is always changing, but it is in no danger of becoming extinct (see Figure 12.3). The normal changes that are constantly taking place in any spoken language cause shifts over time that can make the version of the language spoken decades or centuries earlier almost unintelligible to contemporary speakers; the English spoken in the Middle Ages is a good example of this. Similarly, some so-called "dead" languages such as Latin or Ancient

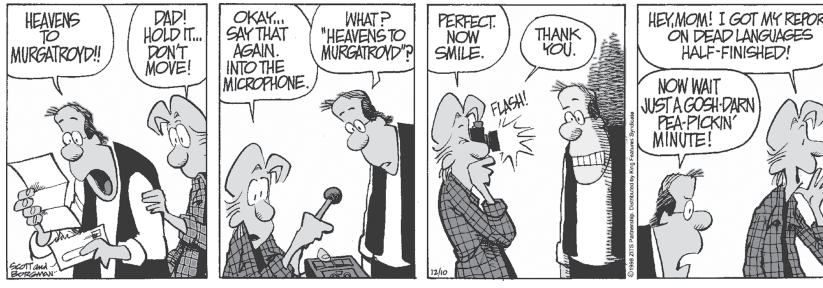


Figure 12.3 Cartoon depicting normal and inevitable changes in a language over time.

Source: "Zits" by Jerry Scott and Jim Borgman, December 10, 1998. Reproduced with kind permission of Dan Piraro and Bizarro.com. Distributed by King Features Syndicate.

Greek never became extinct in the ways described in this chapter but rather gradually evolved into other languages (Italian and Spanish, for example, in the case of Latin, and Modern Greek in the case of Ancient Greek). While our focus in this chapter is on languages that are truly in danger of extinction, it is certainly interesting to note that English, the most commonly spoken language out of the thousands of languages in the world according to Ethnologue's estimate, can be perceived by some to be under threat.

Why Do Languages Die?

The processes by which a language becomes extinct are on one level quite simple: either the speakers of that language all die, or they all stop transmitting their language to their children. In actual cases, however, the factors are usually more complicated. All the speakers of a language can be killed by natural causes, such as the eruption of a volcano on the island of Sumbawa in the Indonesian archipelago in 1815 that caused the death of all the speakers of the Tamboran language (Nettle and Romaine 2000:51). Or human actions may result in language death, as was the case after a peasant uprising in El Salvador in 1932 led to the targeting and killing of 25,000 Indians. Those Indians who were not killed during this period stopped using their native languages for fear of reprisals (Nettle and Romaine 2000:6). Many native languages also became extinct as a result of colonialism, when their speakers died directly from violence or, more indirectly, through exposure to new germs. Languages have also been lost when their speakers have had to relocate for economic or political reasons.

Most of the time, however, the process of language death is more gradual and less overtly violent. Language contact occurs, and the speakers of the less dominant language economically, politically, or socially either decide or are forced to shift to the more dominant language. An "ideology of contempt" (Grillo 1989:173–174, cited in Dorian 1998:7) may come to characterize the less dominant language, and its speakers no longer wish to be associated with it. As we saw in Chapter 4 with Taiap, the transition can be unintentional, with parents not realizing that they were transmitting to their children the negative language ideologies they had toward the endangered language (Kulick 1992). The end result is that children are exposed to

less and less of the endangered language, and the negative attitudes they often absorb in the process make them ill-disposed toward using the language if they do acquire it.

In some cases, the shift is painful, involving a great deal of psychological, if not physical, violence. In many US Bureau of Indian Affairs schools, for example, children of Native Americans were taken away from their parents and forbidden to speak their native languages. In other schools, such as those in Wales in the nineteenth century, children were forced to wear a wooden badge (in other schools, it was just a button or a piece of paper) called a "Welsh Not" if a teacher caught them speaking their native language. They were then told to transfer the "Welsh Not" badge to any other student who was speaking Welsh. Whoever had the badge at the end of the week was punished with flogging (Nettle and Romaine 2000:140–141; Crystal 2000:84–85).

As a language is in the process of dying out, it often undergoes simplification in its grammar and lexicon. Speakers have fewer opportunities to use the language and so either forget or do not acquire a large vocabulary. Grammatical structures can also be lost or simplified. For example, in Dyirbal, an endangered Aboriginal language in Australia, there used to be a four-part classification of nouns. (See Chapter 5 for a discussion of the four categories.) Nowadays, however, young people are less familiar with the ancestral myths and cultural practices that motivated the four-part classification, and they are less fluent in Dyirbal, having attended school mostly in English, and so they have replaced the four-part system of noun classification with a two-part one. It is still different from English and retains some of the features of the older system, but it has become much simpler to use (Nettle and Romaine 2000:66–69).

As a language dies, it disappears from various domains of use. For some languages, this is a top-down process in which the language is no longer used in public domains or official institutions but is retained, at least for a while, in the home. For other languages, the process is a bottom-up one in which the language is no longer used in the home or in everyday contexts but is kept in official and public domains. The languages mentioned at the outset of this chapter in reference to the last speakers of Mbabaram, Manx, Kayardild, Wappo, and Ubykh are examples of top-down language loss because the language disappeared from public, ceremonial contexts first and

was retained only in informal, everyday settings. Languages that have experienced bottom-up loss are mostly those in which sacred texts or religious ceremonies continue to be read or performed in the endangered language, while the language of other domains shifts to something else. Hebrew experienced bottom-up language loss for most of the 2,000 years of the Jewish diaspora. During these years, Hebrew continued to be used mostly by Jewish men as they studied sacred texts and performed religious rituals, but for all other purposes, other languages were used, either the local languages of the area where the Jews lived, or alternative Jewish languages that emerged, such as Yiddish or Ladino.

Of course, Hebrew did not eventually die out, unlike many other endangered languages, which brings us to the final question of this chapter: can languages be brought back from the brink?

Can Endangered Languages Be Saved?

Hebrew is a fascinating, and in many ways unique, case. Its speakers were scattered around the world after the destruction of the Second Temple in Jerusalem in 70 CE and were subject to persecution in the form of pogroms and eventually the Holocaust, which caused the death of six million Jews. In addition, some Jews assimilated partially or totally into the societies in which they lived, giving up Hebrew altogether. For many Jews, however, Hebrew remained in use in religious contexts, mainly by men, and so it never really became "extinct" in the way that so many indigenous languages have. Nevertheless, Hebrew was not used for any everyday conversations for almost 2,000 years (Hinton 2001; Kuzar 2001).

In the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century, some Jews began to return to their ancestral home in Palestine in the hope of one day reestablishing a Jewish state there. The question of which language should be the official language of the new state arose, and the main debate was between Hebrew, the language of the Jewish religion's sacred texts, and Yiddish, the Jewish language that emerged in Eastern Europe. Yiddish, which is written using the Hebrew alphabet, is a combination of Hebrew, German, and other languages, as well as its own unique words and grammatical structures (Jacobs 2005; Weinreich 2008). The language ideologies held by many Jews at the

end of the nineteenth century considered Hebrew to be a language of high prestige, while Yiddish was stigmatized as a lowly language fit only for everyday, non-sacred contexts. Given these ideologies, it is not surprising that Hebrew was chosen to be the official language of the new state of Israel. The process of revitalizing and adapting Biblical Hebrew for use in the modern era was an involved one, with Eliezer Ben-Yehuda coining thousands of new words. Biblical Hebrew was his main source for roots, but there were many words needed for contemporary usage of the language that had to be created from scratch. Ironically, whereas once Hebrew was endangered and Yiddish was spoken by millions of people, now Hebrew is spoken by millions of people and Yiddish is endangered. Still, there is a rich literature in Yiddish, and efforts to preserve the language are growing rapidly (Lansky 2004; Shandler 2005).

No other language has thus far succeeded in being brought back from the brink to the extent that Hebrew has, most likely because of the unique circumstances that surrounded Hebrew's disappearance from everyday conversations and then its return under the aegis of a new nation-state, but many language revitalization efforts are underway around the world. In some cases, there are no longer any speakers of the language left, but sometimes descendants of a "sleeping language" (Hinton 2001:413) find written or recorded materials and attempt to learn the language. When speakers of an endangered language are still alive, they are sometimes brought into the language preservation effort as teachers or leaders. Collaborative, community-based programs such as "language nests" that immerse young children in environments in which they can learn endangered languages can succeed, in some cases, in raising the prestige associated with those languages, thereby improving the chances that people will want to keep speaking their languages and keep teaching them to their children. Indeed, one of the 2010 MacArthur Foundation "Genius" grant recipients was Jessie Little Doe Baird, a linguist who is attempting to revive Wampanoag (or Wôpanâak), a language spoken by Native Americans in New England up until about 150 years ago. The recognition of Baird has brought additional prestige to the Wampanoag Language Reclamation Project and many other such efforts. Unfortunately, as Muehlmann notes, "we cannot conclude that saving languages or rainforests will reverse the social processes that marginalize some groups in the first place" (2007:31).

Conclusion

Language endangerment is a subject that can be illuminated in valuable ways using the insights and methods of linguistic anthropology. The four key terms introduced in the first chapter of this book can lead us toward a deeper understanding of this phenomenon. Remembering that language is always *multifunctional* can help prevent simplistic, if well-intentioned, efforts that assume a one-to-one mapping of languages onto ethnic or national identities. Habitual linguistic *practices* can create patterns related to the cultural norms and social meanings associated with endangered languages. In turn, these practices often *index* particular identities, hierarchies, or values. The *language ideologies* that emerge from this process of indexicality can affect the likelihood of a language's survival.

At the root of language endangerment, wherever it manifests itself around the world, are issues related to social power and individual or collective agency. We turn in the next and final chapter of the book, therefore, to a discussion of these matters, which must inform any investigation of language in actual social contexts.